

Slowing down, on *purpose*.

When the people we help are decades older than us, our usual pace becomes a barrier. Six things worth remembering before — and during — every visit.

*Our speed is their
disorientation. Our patience
is their dignity.*

i. Eyes & reading

Make it bigger before anything else.

They may have been squinting through the whole conversation.

Hold the screen where they can see it.

Their close-focus distance is shorter than yours.

Name the icon — don't just point.

"The gear in the corner," not "tap that thing."

Use the built-in zoom.

Pinch-to-zoom and the magnifier work right now, no setup.

iii. Memory & overload

Write the steps on paper.

They can re-read them long after you've left the room.

Teach one path, not three.

One reliable way beats three half-remembered ones.

Have them do it — twice.

Watching you doesn't build memory; their own hands do.

Always show the way home.

Knowing how to return to the home screen ends the panic.

v. Updates & change

Warn them before you update.

A surprise new layout feels like the device broke.

Stay through the first use after.

"Where did it go?" is when they need you most.

Photograph the home screen first.

Easier to restore the icon arrangement they trust.

Defer the optional ones.

Not every red dot deserves to be tapped today.

ii. Hands & touch

Brace the device, not their finger.

Steadying the phone stops a tremor from becoming a swipe.

A stylus is a quiet miracle.

One firm point beats a trembling fingertip every time.

Their tap looks like a long-press.

Older fingers linger; the OS reads it as a hold.

Turn on touch accommodations.

iOS and Android both have settings made for tremor.

iv. Hearing & pace

Wait ten full seconds.

Forming a reply takes time. Silence isn't confusion.

Face them, not the screen.

Lip-reading and hearing aids both need eye contact.

Lower your pitch, not your volume.

High frequencies fade first with age — bass cuts through.

One instruction at a time.

"Tap the green button" lands; chained steps don't.

vi. Dignity & trust

Hand the device back.

Your job is to teach, not to perform.

Hesitation isn't incompetence — it's caution.

They've been burned before. Treat it as wisdom.

Don't fix and run.

Confirm they can do it themselves before you leave.

"Let me check" beats guessing.

They can always tell when you're bluffing.